stevemakrisedit

Travel Radio Australia, and we're here at the fabulous MIPCOM event in Khan, on the French Ruby area. I've run into the fabulous Steve George Macris, and welcome Steve to Khan and MIPCOM. And Steve runs a great new show for television called The Seventh Seat.

And it's going to be absolutely huge, not only in Australia but from what I've heard around the world. First of all, tell us a bit about your background and how you got into this and the seventh seat itself. Thanks, Geoff.

The idea of the seventh seat first came to mind about 15 years ago. It was just a seat of an idea, and the original concept was I was just going to invite six strangers to my home, give them a dining experience. That was the initial idea.

It was something that never eventuated. Moving forward, I was travelling around Australia, I'd never seen Australia in my van. One night in the Northern Territory, I had this idea, and I thought, what am I going to do with my life? And that's when that memory of the seventh seat came through, and I thought, what am I going to call it? Because I knew it was always going to be six strangers, and I thought, the host, that's seven.

And that's when I thought, that's a great idea, seventh seat. Yeah, I called it the seventh seat, so essentially what it is basically turned an analogue environment into a digital space where six strangers come for dinner. They've never, ever met before, and I have a master chef or a good celebrity chef in the background.

The food's the backdrop, it's not a cooking show or anything like that. So basically the guests roll up, they don't know each other, they don't know what they're going to be eating, et cetera. They turn up wearing sunglasses, the reason being I want to cause a bit of friction, so they're like, I wonder who that person is, you know? It's like the eyes are the windows of the soul.

Yeah, they sit down, they have dinner. It's just incredible what happened through the dinner, like the stories that emerged, the friendships that end up towards the end of it. Like I've done five episodes so far, and all the guests have become all good friends, and some of them have gone into business together.

And so where I'm at at the moment is I'm looking at replicating it in as many countries as I can. Obviously, Australia's the first country, and we're also looking at doing some live activations, but too long to describe. But yeah, that's the premise of the seven seat.

In addition to that, once the dinner finishes, we have a podcast called The Eighth Voice, so basically we get each guest one by one, and they just talk about the show. And I've seen the trailer, it's incredibly high quality content that you're creating here, it's absolutely world class in the photography and the way it's shot. It's absolutely beautiful.

I just saw some of the names that you have on there. They're incredibly well high profile people. Tell us about some of the people you've already had on the show.

That's right, Jeff. So look, I've had just a myriad of people. I've had people that have been in the film industry or radio.

Like, for example, we had Bianca Dye, X Golden Bachelor, and Radio Station. And we had another gentleman, Sean Ryan, who was the founder, I think, of Nova Radio Station, worked for Rupert Murdoch in News Corp. Five-time Olympian Natalie Cook.

It's not about how famous people are. The show is about ordinary people that you'd never know if you saw them in the street, who they are and what their background is. But since then, now, moving forward with the new season, we've got some incredible people.

I've got real big international well-known stars that are coming on this show. They've all agreed. So, yeah.

It's a great concept, Seventh Seat, and the electricity between people. And I suppose some people don't get on. And that's fun, too, to watch, isn't it? Some people sort of clash a little bit.

And, you know, because personalities, you've got six complete strangers. And that's the fun of the show. You never know what's going to happen.

Yeah, it's really interesting you say that. When I did the first episode, I was thinking, what happens if people don't get along? What happens if someone just has a blue with someone? But the funny thing is, everyone's just been so respectful. And I don't think they're sort of like pretending.

It's just like, I think it's just the environment and just the beautiful food that comes out and people just feel like they can open up. They feel at home. They don't feel like they're on camera.

It's like they've just met randomly. There's no competition. Although sometimes I think it'd be interesting to see a bit of an argument break out, but no.

But also the fact that they're, as you say, opening up about their personal lives and you don't see this real side of people, very often celebrities, you don't see the real them. And that's the beauty of this thing. Yeah, so basically what it's all about, it's who these people are when no one's watching.

A lot of them, you know, in the podcast afterwards when we've done the eighth voice, a lot of them have spoken very openly and said they can't believe how they opened up on the show, said things that they've never told anyone else. And they felt like it felt like they had a bit of a, what's the right word, it felt cathartic for them. And yeah, really interesting what the show does.

It just really opens people up and they go, what do you do? And I go, well, I don't know. And the good thing about this is your guests, they've all achieved something really fantastic in their lives. They've either been celebrities, they've achieved something really great or whatever.

And because I know people like this and they often feel a bit closed off if they feel like they are, you know, super talented or whatever. And they're around other people who haven't done that. And it seems in this scenario, everyone's a somebody who can relate to the other people.

And hence why they're opening up, I suppose. It's just incredible. The other thing I noticed, which is really fascinating and interesting is a lot of them have become friends.

And I'll give you an example. Like so there was one guest, Sarah Johnson, that came on the show and she works directly with Wim Hof. I mean, we were going to have Wim Hof on the show, but just logistically, he couldn't make it there in time for the filming.

He was replaced by another guy called Master Yang, amazing human being. In the same episode, there was a gentleman sitting opposite Sarah, Ian Jacobs, from Brisbane, three time world champion kickboxer. And in one of the other episodes, Megan Jarvis.

Anyway, long story short, now they're all collaborating together in doing things like wellness retreats and so on and so forth. And what really just it's just it's incredible the friendships, the business partnerships that have emerged out of the show. And I'm just excited.

Like we haven't even started like in the next 100, 200, 300 episodes. Who knows what's going to happen? And you're here at MIPCOM because the great thing about your format, it's a repeatable format across the world. And so it could be something like an American Idol where the format is copied locally and put into the UK, Europe all over the place.

And I suppose you've designed it like that. Yeah, from the outset, it's exactly what it was designed for, like in the in the first five episodes, I'm hosting it. But it was never about me.

The seventh seat is the host and it's a wild card. It's an enigma. So basically, in future episodes, no one's going to know who that host is going to be.

But yes, like you said, it was the way the architecture was laid out. So it can be agnostic. It can be localised and adapted in its format.

And I've come here at MIPCOM to see, you know, which which way I'm going to go. Am I going to go through the traditional broadcasting or do we just bypass it and go on to YouTube? Because obviously YouTube now is becoming the global TV on the planet. Yes, definitely.

And it's great. It's such a magnificent distribution network, YouTube, which is is pretty much free. And it really evens out for producers like yourself.

It really puts you on a level playing field, doesn't it? How is all the barriers to entry? Because I can make decisions. I don't have to sort of follow rules. I can be as creative as I like.

And YouTube allows you to do that. You can just create what you want to create and just go ahead and post it. And as long as it's nothing that doesn't break their guidelines.

But you basically are your own boss and you become the whole ecosystem. And I think the way YouTube is moving forward at the moment, YouTube is the most consumed platform on the planet. I think it's more than Netflix, more than TikTok.

Yeah, your impressions here, you are sitting in the beautiful screen Australia right on the we're overlooking the fabulous Khan Marina here and your impressions of MIPCOM. Is it your first one or have you been coming for a little while? No, no, this is my first MIPCOM. And I'm so glad I came.

I attended MIP or MIP in London in February. And that sort of, you know, sort of paved the way and showed me. And I'm very fortunate.

I'll tell you why it was a last minute decision. And I have to say, I have to give a lot of credit to Screen Australia. They've just been incredible.

I mean, they've welcomed me with open arms. They made the process very easy for me to attend. I feel like I'm at home here.

You know, I've got a place to have my meetings, interviews crash. I shouldn't even give you food and drink. Yes, it's a fabulous spot we have.

And last year they were down in the basement. But this year, we've got probably one of the most premier locations in the whole of the Palais here. And it's the Palais de Khan.

It's the same place. One of one of the drinks waiters coming past. Bonjour monsieur, Savar.

You know, they are working hard to serve us here. And it's fabulous. And yes, we've probably got in the Palais de Khan, we've got probably one of the most beautiful outlooks here.

And congratulations to Screen Australia for securing this for all of the guys such as Steve Mukris, who is putting together the seventh seat, the eighth voice. And you can check it out online, theseventhseat.com. And it's coming to screens near you and YouTube all over the world. And Steve, thank you so much for being part of the program.

And hopefully I can join you as a magician, as a guest as well. Jeff, thank you so much. And you've been absolutely fabulous and really appreciate having a chat and sharing what the seventh seat is all about.

And we'd love to have you on the show. In fact, we're definitely going to have you in one of them. You'll just materialise.

You'll do your magic and you'll be there. Oh, it's always great fun. Steve, thank you very much for being part of the program.

As I say, theseventhseat.com, check it out. It's going to be a fab show worldwide. Thanks, Jeff.

You have a great time here at MIPCOM. And I'm sure we're going to catch up when you're back in Australia. Yasu, Kalispera.

Yasu, my friend, Yasu.